

A woman with long dark hair is wrapped in a white sheet, standing in a room with brick walls and a bed. Studio lighting is visible on the left.

PHOTO SHOOT

Gone Wrong

*He even made me record
my girlfriend cheating*

EVAN SLATE

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cheating

Evan Slate

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I pulled up outside Meridian around nine-thirty, the restaurant still lit up behind its tall chic windows. I could see Danielle through the glass standing at the hostess stand in her uniform, the black dress and heels they make her wear, her hair pulled back in that sleek ponytail that made her look older and more sophisticated than I knew she felt. She always undersold herself.

She saw my car and held up one finger, mouthed "one minute," and I watched her finish whatever she was doing, saying goodbye to someone I couldn't see, and then she was walking out through the heavy glass doors into the cool night air.

When she got in the car she was wearing that energized smile she got sometimes after a really good shift. She leaned over and kissed me quickly before buckling her seatbelt.

"How was it?" I asked, pulling away from the curb.

"Busy. Good tips tonight, even though I only seat people and technically shouldn't get any." She was pulling her hair out of the ponytail, shaking it loose. "Oh also, that photographer guy came in again."

"That guy you mentioned?" I said, merging into traffic.

"Dillon, yeah. He's so nice. He always remembers my name and asks how I'm doing, like actually cares, not the fake way most people me in there are."

I'd heard about this Dillon a few times over the past couple months, always in passing, another regular at the posh restaurant, the kind of place that attracted business lunches and expense account dinners, men in suits making deals over expensive steaks and wine that cost more than our weekly groceries.

"Did he have some famous clients with him again?" I asked.

"No, it was just him tonight. He sat at the bar so we talk during my break. He showed me some of his work on his phone, even, it was so cool."

"Oh yeah? What kind of stuff?"

"Like, promotional shoots he called it? He actually did the campaign for the new Marvel movie, the character posters? He works with musicians too, album covers and press photos, I bet you know some! He showed me one he did of this actress, I forget her name, but I recognize her face. It was incredible, like the lighting and everything, she looked amazing." She shook her head in wonder.

I listened to her talk, hearing the excitement in her voice. I felt good that she'd had a good night, that someone had paid attention to her in a way that made her feel special. I wasn't worried about it because Danielle wasn't the kind of girl who attracted that kind of attention usually, or at least she didn't think she was, and some photographer being friendly at her workplace seemed harmless enough.

"Sounds so interesting," I said.

"He said something today," Danielle said. Her voice changing slightly, quieter. "He said I have incredible bone structure." She blushed.

"You do," I said automatically.

"No, I mean like, for photography. He said I'd photograph really well, that I should think about doing some test shoots."

I glanced over at her and she was looking out the window. I could see the flush on her cheeks even in the dim light from the dashboard.

"Like modeling?" I asked.

"I guess? I don't know. He said test shoots, like just for practice, building a portfolio. He said he's always looking for faces that are interesting on camera."

"That's pretty cool," I said. And I meant it, it felt genuinely good that someone had noticed what I'd always known, that Danielle was beautiful even if she didn't believe it herself.

She didn't say anything else about it on the drive home, just talked about other things from her shift, the rude customer who'd complained about the wait even though they didn't have a reservation, the manager who'd let some staff leave early because it was slow at the end of the night.

When we got home she changed out of her black dress into leggings and one of my old t-shirts. I made us late dinner because it was late and neither of us wanted anything complicated. We ate at the small table in our apartment's tiny kitchen.

"So you're interested?" I asked between bites. "In the photo thing?"

She looked up at me, surprised I'd brought it back up. "I don't know. Maybe? It's probably nothing, just something people say to be nice."

"He showed you his work though, right? Like actual professional stuff. Doesn't sound like he was just being nice."

"I guess." She wound pasta around her fork, not eating it. "It would be weird though, wouldn't it? I don't know anything about modeling or posing or any of that stuff."

"That's probably the point of test shoots," I said. "To learn. Could be fun. Could be good for your confidence, too."

She looked at me then trying to figure out if I meant it or if I was just saying what I thought she wanted to hear. I smiled at her to show I was being genuine.

"You wouldn't think it was weird?" she asked.

"Why would it be weird?"

"I don't know. Some guy wanting to take pictures of me?"

"A professional photographer who works with celebrities wanting to help you build a portfolio?" I corrected. "That's not just some guy. And I think you should do it if you want to. You're beautiful and if he can see that through a camera lens then other people will too."

She smiled at that, a real smile that curled her eyes. She reached across the table and squeezed my hand.

"You're so sweet to me," she said.

"I'm just honest," I said.

We finished dinner and cleaned up and settled into the couch to watch something, some show we'd been working through. Danielle curled up against my side the way she always did, her head on my shoulder and her legs tucked under her.

But I noticed she was more animated than usual when she talked, more awake and alert, and when I asked her what she was thinking about she said "nothing really," but I could tell she was thinking about the photography thing, about Dillon, about the possibility of being seen differently than she saw herself.

Later when we went to bed she was quiet and thoughtful, and when we had sex it was the way it always was with us, gentle and careful and a little bit restrained, Danielle with her eyes closed and her breathing controlled, me trying to read her signals and give her what she needed, though she

could never say it, and when we finished, she curled up on her side and fell asleep quickly while I lay awake for a while just thinking about nothing.

It was just a regular customer at her work who'd said something nice to her. I was being a supportive boyfriend by encouraging her to take the opportunity if she wanted it. I fell asleep feeling nothing but good about it, feeling like I was doing the right thing.

I had no idea that I was already making a choice, that my encouragement was the first step in a direction I didn't know we were heading, that every time I said "you should do it" or "it could be good for you" I was giving permission for something I didn't understand yet.

But that night, lying in our bed with Danielle asleep beside me and the city quiet outside our window, I felt like a good boyfriend, supportive and secure. I had no reason to think anything would change about that.

Two weeks later Danielle came home from her shift with that same energized quality she'd had the night Dillon first mentioned the photos, and when I asked how work was, she said Dillon had come in again.

"He sat at the bar for lunch," she said, kicking off her high heels by the door. "Just him, no clients. We talked on my break. He's so nice to me!"

I was making dinner, chopping vegetables for a stir fry. I said something about that being nice without really thinking about it.

"He brought up the photo thing again," Danielle said. I looked over at her. She was leaning against the counter watching me, her arms crossed. She had this expression I couldn't quite read, excited and nervous at the same time.

"Oh yeah?" I said.

"He said he was serious about it. That he wants to do a whole session, build a portfolio for me. No charge or anything, he said it would be for his portfolio too, like collaborative."

"That's pretty cool," I said, going back to the vegetables.

"He showed me his Instagram on his phone. Shane, his work is incredible! Like, really! There were photos of people I recognized, actresses from shows we watch, and musicians, and the photos were just... I don't know, they made everyone look so amazing."

I could hear the awe in her voice and I put down the knife and turned to face her.

"So what did you say?" I asked.

"I said I'd think about it? But that I wanted to talk to my boyfriend first."

She was looking at me carefully, trying to gauge my reaction. I felt the weight of the moment, felt like this was some kind of test of whether I was a secure boyfriend or an insecure one, whether I trusted her or didn't.

And honestly, I did trust her. Danielle wasn't the type to do anything behind my back, wasn't the type to even think about other men that way. She was shy and reserved and completely loyal, and the idea of some photographer being a threat seemed ridiculous.

Plus I genuinely thought it could be good for her. She'd been talking more about wanting to build her confidence, about feeling invisible sometimes, about wanting to feel like she was more than just the girl who seated people at a restaurant. If professional photos could help with that, then why would I stand in the way?

"I think you should do it," I said.

"Really?" Her face lit up, that genuine surprised happiness that made me feel like I'd said exactly the right thing.

"Yeah, really. He's a professional, he does this for a living. If he thinks you'd photograph well then you probably would. Could be a cool experience."

"You don't think it's too weird?"

"Why would it be weird?"

"I don't know, some guy wanting to take pictures of me."

"A professional photographer wanting to add to his portfolio," I said, echoing what I'd said before. "That's his job. And you're beautiful, so it makes sense he'd want to photograph you."

She came over and hugged me, wrapping her arms around my waist and pressing her face against my chest. I put my arms around her and felt good, felt like I was being the boyfriend I wanted to be, supportive and secure and encouraging.

That night after dinner she got her phone out and sat on the couch composing a text to Dillon. I sat next to her half watching TV and half watching her type and delete and retype the message over and over.

"You have his number?"

"He wanted me to take it."

"What are you trying to say?" I asked after maybe the fifth version.

"I don't know, I don't want to sound too eager but I also don't want to sound like I'm not interested."

"Just tell him you'd like to do it and ask when works for him."

She typed something, showed it to me. "Hi Dillon, I talked to my boyfriend and I'd love to do the photo session if you're still interested. Let me know when would work for you."

"Perfect," I said. She hit send before she could second-guess it.

His response came back within thirty seconds. Danielle's phone lit up and she grabbed it and read it and her whole face changed, got bright and excited.

"What'd he say?" I asked.

"He said he's really glad I want to do it! That he has some great ideas for the shoot! He gave me his studio address and three different days I can choose from."

She texted back and forth with him for a few minutes while I half watched the show, and when she put her phone down she was smiling in that way I hadn't seen, like she was genuinely excited about possibilities.

Over the next few days leading up to the session she talked about it constantly. She researched poses on Instagram, showed me examples of photos she liked, asked me what she should wear. I told her to just wear normal clothes, that Dillon would probably have ideas about what worked for the camera. She seemed satisfied with that answer.

The session was scheduled for a Thursday afternoon, during a time Danielle had off from the restaurant. I'd be at work at the studio where I did motion capture and rigging, the kind of technical creative work that paid the bills but wasn't particularly glamorous or interesting to talk about at parties. People don't know the factory that gaming animation really is.

That Thursday morning before I left for work Danielle was already up and nervous, changing outfits multiple times, doing her makeup and then wiping it off and starting over.

"You look great," I told her, kissing her goodbye at the door. "Just relax and have fun."

"I'm so nervous," she said.

"It'll be fine. He's a professional, he knows what he's doing. Just trust him."

She nodded and I left for work, and around noon when I knew she'd be heading to the studio I texted her: "Have fun, you'll be great."

She sent back a nervous smiley face emoji and I put my phone away and went back.

I was proud of myself. Proud that I wasn't the jealous controlling boyfriend, that I could be supportive of Danielle doing something outside of us, that I trusted her completely. Could it be that I was growing too?

It didn't occur to me that trust wasn't the issue, that the problem wasn't whether Danielle would intentionally do something wrong, but whether she'd recognize the moment when things stopped being professional and started being something else.

It didn't occur to me that by encouraging this, by telling her to trust Dillon, by framing it as good for her confidence, I was setting up a situation where she'd be less likely to see the lines getting crossed, because I'd told her there was nothing to worry about.

I checked my phone hoping for an update. I had no reason to expect anything other than Danielle having a good professional experience that would make her feel good about herself.

I went back to work and didn't think about it again until my phone buzzed an hour later with a text from Danielle, and when I opened it, my heart leapt.

The text just said "Done!! Picking me up at 5!?" There was something about the exclamation points, about the energy in even that short message, that made me feel something.

I texted back "Yeah, see you in a bit," and I told myself I was being ridiculous, told myself I was reading into nothing. I finished at work and drove to the address Danielle had given me feeling nothing but curiosity about how it had gone.

The address led me to an industrial area I didn't know well, old warehouse buildings that had been converted into lofts and studios and expensive apartments. I found parking on the vacant dusty street and texted Danielle that I was outside.

She came out two minutes later through a heavy metal door with a small sign that said "Studio D" next to it, and the second I saw her face I knew something had changed.

She was glowing, that's the only word for it. Her whole face was bright and energized and alive in a way I hadn't seen before, and when she got in the car, she was already fast talking before she'd even closed the door.

"Shane, oh my god, that was incredible! The studio is amazing! It's this huge open space with these massive windows and all this professional lighting equipment. Dillon was so patient, he taught me everything, how to

stand and where to look and how to find my light, that's what he called it, finding your light, and how to relax my face because apparently I was tensing my jaw without realizing it." She laughed.

She was talking rapidly, barely pausing for breath. I pulled away from the curb listening to her and watching her out of the corner of my eye, seeing this energy radiating off her that I couldn't remember seeing before.

"What did you shoot?" I asked when she paused.

"Just headshots today. He said we'd start simple, build up to more complex stuff later. But even just headshots, Shane, there's so much to it! The angle of your face, the way the light hits you, whether you're looking at the camera or away, all these tiny things that make such a big difference."

"Sounds like he knows what he's doing," I said.

"He's so good at it. He'd adjust the lights and then show me the difference on his screen, like 'see how this light makes your cheekbones more defined' or 'see how this angle makes your eyes look bigger,' and I could actually see it. And he was so encouraging, kept saying I was a natural, that I had really expressive eyes."

I listened to her talk the whole drive home, asking questions here and there but mostly just letting her go. I felt happy for her, felt like I'd done good to encourage it, because whatever happened in that studio had clearly been good for her confidence.

When we got home she immediately pulled out her phone and said Dillon had already sent her some of the shots, just a few quick edits to show her. She pulled them up and showed me.

I looked at the photos and felt something heavy in my chest.

She looked incredible, not just pretty or nice, but incredible, professional, like someone I didn't recognize. The lighting made her features look sculpted, made her eyes look huge and luminous, made her skin look flawless, and there was something in her expression, too, something secretive and knowing, that I'd never seen when I looked at her in person.

"These are amazing," I said and I meant it, I felt genuinely amazed by how hot she looked.

"Right? I can't believe that's me. I kept looking at his screen during the shoot and being like, who is that person?" She laughed in wonder.

She swiped through the photos, maybe a dozen of them, all headshots from different angles with different expressions. In each one she looked like

someone who belonged in a magazine or on a billboard, someone who knew she was beautiful and wasn't afraid of it.

"He said these are just the quick ones," Danielle said. "He's going to do full edits and send me more later this week."

We made dinner together and she kept talking about the session, about things Dillon had taught her, about the studio space, about how professional everything was.

That night when we went to bed Danielle initiated sex, which was rare for her, usually it was me who started things. She was more responsive than usual, too more alert, making small sounds when she normally kept quiet, and when we finished she seemed satisfied in a way that felt different.

I noticed it but I didn't fully connect it to the photo session yet, just thought she was in a good mood, thought the confidence from having a good experience was carrying over into other parts of her life.

But I woke up a few hours later, Danielle asleep beside me. I lay in the dark thinking about the photos, about how different she'd looked, about the confidence in her expression that I'd never seen in person.

There was something about it that made me feel proud but also unsettled in a way I couldn't say.

She'd looked like someone else, someone more confident, more aware of her own beauty, someone who existed in a different world than the one we lived in together.

I told myself I was being weird, that of course she looked different in professional photos, that was literally the point of professional photography. I turned over and tried to go back to sleep.

The next morning I woke up before Danielle and made coffee, and when she came out of the bedroom still in her pajamas she grabbed her phone immediately and smiled.

"Dillon texted," she said, and something in my stomach tightened at how quickly she'd checked, at the smile on her face.

"Yeah?" I said, trying to sound casual.

She showed me her phone. The text said: "Great session yesterday. When can we do it again?"

"What are you going to say?" I asked.

"I don't know, when do you think? Next week sometime?"

She was already typing, her thumbs moving quickly. I watched her compose the message: "I'd love to! I'm free Tuesday or Thursday

afternoon?"

She sent it and put her phone down and went to make herself coffee. I stood watching her move around the kitchen with this new energy, this brightness that hadn't been there before yesterday.

Her phone buzzed maybe thirty seconds later and she grabbed it and read it and smiled again.

"He said Thursday works, same time. He says he wants to do more than just headshots this time, maybe some full body shots with different poses."

"Cool," I said, my voice sounding normal even though I felt something else, something that wasn't quite worry but wasn't quite comfort either.

Danielle was excited for the rest of the morning, talking about what she might wear, looking up poses on Instagram again. I went to work and spent the day trying not to think about it.

But I couldn't stop thinking about it, how she'd looked like a different person, how animated and alive she'd been talking about Dillon and the studio and the session.

I couldn't stop thinking about how she'd been in bed last night, either, more responsive than usual, and how that had happened right after spending two hours with another man who'd been looking at her so closely, directing her, telling her she was beautiful and expressive and natural.

I told myself I was being paranoid, that this was good for her, that I should be happy she'd found something that made her feel so good.

I went back to work and pushed the thoughts away and told myself everything was fine.

But that night when Danielle showed me more photos Dillon had sent, fully edited this time, even more beautiful than the quick ones from yesterday, I looked at them and felt that same complicated feeling, proud and unsettled at the same time. I didn't know what to do with it so I smiled and told her she looked amazing.

And she did. She looked amazing. She looked like someone I was lucky to have, someone other men would want to have.

I couldn't shake the feeling that the person in those photos wasn't quite the same person who slept next to me every night. I didn't know if that was something to worry about or something to celebrate.

A few days later over breakfast Danielle mentioned casually, like it was nothing, that Dillon had come into the restaurant the day before.

"He sat at the bar for my break," she said, spreading jam on her toast.
"We talked about Thursday."

I looked up from my coffee. "What about it?"

"He wants to do more than just headshots this time. Full body shots, different poses, maybe some outfit changes. I told you."

"What kind of outfits?" I asked, trying to keep my tone neutral and curious rather than suspicious.

"He has a whole wardrobe at the studio, professional stuff. He said he'd pull some options that would work well on camera."

"That's cool," I said. And it was cool, it made sense, professional photographers would have clothes for shoots. I went back to my coffee and my phone and try not to think about it.

Thursday came and I was at work doing motion capture cleanup, tedious technical work that should have occupied my full attention but didn't. I kept checking my phone, looking at the time, calculating how long the session would take, wondering how it was going.

I told myself I was just curious, just interested in how Danielle's new hobby was developing, but there was something else underneath that, something I didn't want to examine too closely.

At five I left work and drove to the studio, and when Danielle came out, she had that same glow again, that same energized quality. In the car she talked rapidly about the session.

"He taught me so much about posing, about how to create lines with your body, how to make yourself look taller or more dynamic, where to put your hands so they don't look awkward. There's so much to think about, like your shoulders and your hips and the angle of your chin, all these tiny adjustments that change how you photograph."

"Sounds complicated," I said.

"It is, but Dillon's so good at teaching it. He was really hands-on today, like constantly adjusting my body, moving my shoulder down or tilting my chin up or shifting my hips. Just little things but they made such a big difference in the photos."

I felt something tighten in my chest at "hands-on" and "little touches" but I kept my voice casual. "Oh yeah?"

"Yeah, and he'd pose me and then come over and adjust me and then go back to the camera and shoot, and then adjust me again. He said it's normal, that photographers have to be physical sometimes to get the pose right."

"Makes sense," I said. And it did make sense, it objectively made sense, but something about the way she said it made me uncomfortable.

When we got home she pulled up the photos Dillon had sent and I looked through them. She was right, they were different from the headshots, more dynamic, more confident.

She was in different outfits, too, things I didn't recognize, professional-looking clothes that fit her well. In each photo she was posed differently, her body creating lines and shapes like she said. She looked beautiful and confident and somehow more adult than she usually did.

"These are great," I said. But there was something about them, something that made me feel like I was looking at a version of Danielle that existed only in that studio with Dillon.

That night she came onto me for sex again, even more eager than last time, more vocal, and afterward when she fell asleep I lay there thinking about what she'd said, about Dillon being hands-on, about his hands on her shoulders and her hips and her chin.

Professional adjustments. That's what she'd said. That's what they were.

But over the next week Danielle mentioned Dillon twice more, mentioned that he'd come into the restaurant more too.

"He had clients with him on Tuesday," she said one night. "Business lunch, he waved at me a little private wave when they left."

"And yesterday?" I asked, because she'd mentioned him coming in yesterday too.

"Oh, he was alone. Sat at the bar and had lunch so we could talk."

"What did you guys talk about?" I asked, trying to sound curious rather than suspicious.

"Just photography stuff mostly. People react differently to it, not just the subject like me, but others." She glanced at me. "He's teaching me a lot, like about lighting and composition and what makes a strong photo. And he tells me about shoots he's doing, celebrities he's working with. It's so interesting."

I nodded and didn't push it, but that night after she fell asleep I was thinking about Dillon coming into the restaurant alone, about them talking so much during her breaks, about whether this was actually professional development or whether the whole thing was something else, like an excuse to spend time together.

Was I being paranoid? Was I seeing something that wasn't there?

Danielle wasn't the type to cheat, wasn't the type to even think about other men, and everything she'd described sounded professional and appropriate.

But there was something about how she talked about him, about how animated she got, about how she'd mentioned him coming to the restaurant like it was nothing when it felt like something.

Then there was the fact that she was different now, more confident and more sexual and more alive, and all of that had started when Dillon had started photographing her, when he'd started looking at her and touching her and telling her she was beautiful.

I told myself I was being insecure, that I should be happy she was gaining confidence, that I should trust her the way I'd always trusted her.

But I couldn't shake the feeling that something was happening that I didn't fully understand, that the professional photographer thing was maybe not just professional, or maybe it was professional but that didn't mean it was innocent.

I didn't say anything to Danielle, didn't ask her not to see him, didn't suggest she stop the sessions, didn't voice any of my concerns because what would I even say? Don't let your photographer touch you to adjust your poses? Don't talk to him when he comes into your restaurant? Don't be excited about something that makes you feel so good?

I'd told her to do this. I'd encouraged it. I'd been the supportive boyfriend who said it would be good for her confidence. And it had been, and now I was lying awake at night wondering if I'd made a big mistake.

I still didn't say anything, still didn't do anything, just watched and wondered and felt that uncomfortable feeling growing in my chest. I told myself that next session I'd ask more questions, I'd pay more attention, I'd figure out if there was actually something to worry about or if I was just being paranoid.

I repeated that to myself lying in the dark next to Danielle. And I almost believed it, too, but not quite, and that "not quite" was enough to keep me awake for a long time thinking about hands adjusting shoulders and hips and chins, about conversations during breaks, about the way Danielle's face lit up whenever she talked about him.

I fell asleep eventually, unsettled and uncertain. I woke up the next morning with the same questions and no answers and no plan for what to do about any of it.

By the fourth session a routine had established itself. Danielle would go Thursday afternoons, come home glowing and energized, show me photos that made her look like someone I barely recognized, and that night she'd be more responsive and passionate in bed than she'd ever been before the sessions started.

I noticed the pattern but I didn't say anything about it, just accepted it as part of this new thing in our lives, this hobby she'd picked up that was so good for her confidence.

One Thursday she came home and said, "Dillon suggested you should come watch a session sometime. He said some photographers don't like observers but he's totally fine with it, thinks it could be cool for you to see how it all works."

She was excited about the idea, her face bright and open. I felt conflicted immediately, felt caught between wanting to see what actually happened in that studio and not wanting to seem like I didn't trust her, like I needed to supervise.

"If you want me to," I said carefully.

"I think it would be fun! You could see what we do, see the setup. And Dillon's really good at explaining everything, you'd probably find it interesting I told him about how you keep asking questions."

I thought about that, but I said yes, and the next Thursday I left work early and met Danielle at the studio instead of picking her up after.

This time I went in through the heavy metal door with the "Studio D" sign, climbing stairs to the second floor where another door stood open.

The studio was bigger than I'd imagined, a huge open loft space with exposed brick walls and enormous windows along one side, currently covered with blackout curtains. Professional lighting equipment stood in clusters around the space, expensive-looking cameras on tripods, backdrops in different colors rolled up against one wall, and racks of clothing lined another wall, everything organized and clean and clearly expensive.

Dillon came over immediately when I walked in, hand extended, big smile on his face.

"Shane, hey man, glad you could make it. I know Dani is too." He shook my hand firmly, confident and friendly. "Let me show you around."

Dani, I thought. I didn't even call her that.

"She's just changing for me," he said and he walked me through the space, pointing out equipment, explaining what different lights did, showing

me the backdrops and the wardrobe. He was easy to talk to, knowledgeable without being condescending. I found myself relaxing slightly, found myself thinking that this was exactly what Danielle had said it was, professional and legitimate.

Danielle emerged a few moments later and Dillon greeted her with a hug, casual and friendly, and then he pointed to a chair in the corner of the studio.

"Shane, you can sit there. Just stay quiet during the actual shooting so Danielle can focus, but feel free to watch everything."

I sat in the chair and watched Dillon and Danielle move to the shooting area, watched him position lights and adjust his camera while she stood waiting in some sweater-dress type thing.

"Okay, let's start with something simple," Dillon said. "Just stand natural, shoulders back, chin up."

Danielle stood the way he'd directed and Dillon moved around her with the camera, clicking, talking the whole time.

"Good, now shift your weight to your left foot. Tilt your head a bit. Perfect."

He came over to her and put his hands on her shoulders, adjusting them down and back.

"You're tensing here, relax."

His hands stayed on her shoulders for a moment and then moved to her hips, shifting them slightly, too.

"Hips forward just a little. Good."

He stepped back and shot more, and then came back and adjusted her chin with his fingers, tilting her face up.

"Eyes to me. Good. Now soften your expression, you're working too hard."

It went like this for maybe thirty minutes, Dillon constantly coaching her, constantly adjusting her physically, his hands on her shoulders, her waist, her hips, her arms, her chin, moving her body into positions and then stepping back to shoot.

The language was professional, all technical direction, but the physical contact was constant. I watched from my chair and tried to figure out how I felt about it.

Danielle responded to his direction immediately, her body shifting the way he wanted it to, her face changing expression on command. I could see

her getting more relaxed as the session went on, more comfortable, more confident.

At one point Dillon stopped shooting and came over to her and said, "I need you to loosen up, you're still holding tension."

He put his hands on her shoulders and massaged them, his fingers pressing into her muscles. I watched Danielle's eyes close slightly, watched her whole body relax under his hands.

"There you go," Dillon said quietly. "Just like that."

He stepped back and picked up his camera again and kept shooting. Danielle was different now, looser and more natural. I sat in my chair watching another man's hands on my girlfriend and telling myself this was professional, this was normal, this was just how photographers worked.

The session ended after about an hour and Dillon showed us some of the shots on his computer screen. They were good, Danielle looked beautiful and confident and alive.

"These are great," Dillon said, scrolling through them. "You're really getting comfortable in front of the camera."

We chatted for a few minutes, Dillon friendly and professional and completely at ease, and then Danielle and I left and got in the car.

"So what did you think?" she asked as I pulled away from the curb.

"It was... professional," I said. And I meant it, it had been professional, but the word felt inadequate, somehow.

"See? I told you. Dillon's really good at what he does."

"Yeah," I said. "He is."

That night Danielle was more passionate than she'd ever been, all over me the second we got into bed, vocal and demanding, and when we finished I lay there seeing the pattern clearly now, seeing the direct connection between the sessions and how she was with me after.

She spent an hour being looked at and touched and directed by Dillon, being told she was beautiful and natural and perfect, and then she came home to me energized and confident and sexual in a way she'd never been.

I was benefiting from it, too. I was getting a more passionate engaged version of Danielle because of what was happening in that studio, because of Dillon's hands on her shoulders and her hips, because of his attention and his praise and his constant physical contact.

But I knew I should probably tell her we need to talk about boundaries, about whether this was actually appropriate, about whether all that touching

is really a good idea.

I didn't want to lose this version of her, though, didn't want to go back to careful restrained sex with the lights off, didn't want to be the insecure boyfriend who couldn't handle his girlfriend doing something that made her feel good and come alive.

I lay there thinking about Dillon's hands massaging her shoulders, about how she'd relaxed under his touch, about how comfortable they'd grown together. I told myself it was fine, it was professional. I'd watched the whole thing and it had been exactly what Danielle said it was.

But I couldn't shake the feeling that I'd seen something I wasn't supposed to see, or maybe that I'd seen exactly what I was supposed to see and that that was the problem.

I fell asleep eventually, Danielle warm beside me. I dreamed about hands adjusting hips and shoulders, about professional distance that didn't feel distant at all. I woke up the next morning with the same uncomfortable feeling sitting in my chest.

The next session I came again. It was becoming routine now, me sitting in the corner chair while Dillon photographed Danielle, watching the process, watching his hands on her body adjusting her poses, watching her respond so attentively to his direction.

Before they started shooting Dillon said he wanted to try something different today. He looked at both of us while he explained it.

"I want to do some intimate shots. Close-up, emotional, vulnerable. These are harder than the posed stuff we've been doing because they're about real feeling, real connection. Danielle, you're going to have to get comfortable, drop your walls, let it sort of flow through you. Feel it."

Danielle nodded, looking nervous and excited at the same time. I sat in my chair feeling that familiar tightness in my chest but not saying anything.

They moved to the shooting area and Dillon positioned her close to the camera. He started coaching her through it.

"Think about something that makes you feel strongly. Something that brings up your emotions. Don't perform it, just let yourself feel it and let it show on your face."

Danielle stood trying, her face shifting through different expressions, but I could see even from where I sat that it wasn't working, that she was too in her head, too aware of the camera.

Dillon lowered his camera and came over to her.

"You're thinking too much about what it looks like, you're not just feeling it," he said gently. "Let me show you something."

He stepped close to her. He curled his hand around her face, his palm against her cheek. And then he kissed her.

It was quick and soft, just a press of his lips against hers, and then he pulled back.

Danielle's eyes went wide, her whole body going still. I sat frozen in my chair watching this, watching another man kiss my girlfriend in front of me.

But Dillon was already talking, already stepping back, casual and professional.

"See? Now you have a real feeling to work with. Now use what you're feeling, whatever it is you're feeling. That surprise, that flutter you're feeling right now, that's real emotion. Let me capture it."

He moved behind the camera and started shooting, clicking rapidly. Danielle stood flushed and uncertain, her hand coming up to touch her mouth where he'd kissed her.

"Beautiful," Dillon murmured. "That's perfect. That's exactly what I need. Just stay with that feeling."

He shot for maybe two minutes and then lowered the camera and looked at me. He was grinning, easy and confident.

"It's just technique, man. Actors do it all the time to generate real emotion. You're cool with that, though, right?"

My mouth opened and I tried to find words, tried to figure out what I was supposed to say. I managed to get out, "Yeah, it's fine."

"Great," Dillon said. He went back to shooting.

I sat watching him photograph Danielle's reaction to being kissed, watching her slowly come back to herself. I didn't know what I felt, didn't know if I should object or if that would make me look insecure.

It was just technique. That's what he'd said. Just a professional method for generating emotion.

But it had been a kiss, his lips on hers, his hand on her face.

Ten minutes later Dillon said he needed to reset her emotion, that she was losing the vulnerability. He came over to her again and kissed her again.

It was longer this time, his hand remaining on her face. I watched Danielle kiss back before he pulled away, watched her lean into it for just a second before she caught herself.

"That's perfect," Dillon said, stepping back to his camera. "Stay right there."

He shot for another few minutes and then called the session, said he had what they needed for today. We all stood around looking at some of the shots on his computer screen.

The photos were incredible, it was true. Danielle looked vulnerable and open and beautiful, her eyes huge and emotional, her mouth parted, everything about her expressing real feeling.

"These are as good as some of my best work," Dillon said, scrolling through them. "You're really developing as a subject, Danielle. You're learning to access real emotion now. We can work with that so much."

In the car afterward Danielle was quiet, not her usual energized self. I drove for a few minutes before I asked, "You okay?"

"Yeah," she said quietly. "Just... that was really intense."

"The kissing thing?" I asked, trying to keep my voice neutral.

"Yeah. I wasn't expecting that. But I guess it worked, right? The photos looked good."

"They did," I said.

"Are you upset?" she asked. Her voice was small and uncertain.

I knew I should have tell her I'm not comfortable with another man kissing her, technique or not.

But I said, "No, I'm not upset. If it's what he needs for the photos, then it should be fine."

She nodded and we drove the rest of the way home in silence, But that night she practically attacked me the second we got into bed, desperate and vocal, pulling at my clothes and telling me she needed me. She sucked me off, swallowed me, a first.

She rode me, too, more passionately than ever, almost frantic, and when she came, she was loud and uninhibited.

I thought about what I'd watched, about Dillon's hand on her face, about the kiss, about the longer second kiss where she'd kissed him back.

Just technique he said, just a professional method for generating emotion. But it looked like more than that. It felt like more than that to me, and the way Danielle reacted, to her too, I could tell.

Danielle's behavior in bed, the desperate way she'd needed me, the passion and intensity, that had to come from somewhere, and I knew it was

from being kissed by the man, from feeling whatever she'd felt in that moment.

I benefitted from Dillon kissing her, it had made her feel something she didn't usually feel, and that feeling was spilling over onto me.

But I should have told her we need to talk about boundaries, should have said I'm not comfortable with the kissing, I should put my foot down.

The way Danielle looked when he kissed her, the surprise and the flutter and the vulnerability, that was real. That wasn't technique on her end, that was genuine reaction.

And the way she'd kissed him back the second time, just slightly, just for a second, that was real too.

I fell asleep eventually, unsettled and confused but also aroused and ashamed. I woke up next morning knowing I would let it continue, knowing I wouldn't say anything, knowing I was making a choice even if I was pretending I wasn't.

I got up and made coffee and when Danielle came out of the bedroom I kissed her good morning and acted like everything was normal. She seemed relieved that I wasn't upset. We went through our day like nothing changed. At least I was there to watch over things.

Over the next few sessions the kissing became part of the normal process, something that happened naturally during shoots. I watched it become normal, watched it stop being shocking and start becoming their little routine.

Dillon would be shooting and he'd lower his camera and say "Got to turn up your energy" and he'd walk over to Danielle and kiss her, long and deeply, her returning it, and then he'd step back and keep shooting, her looking as you'd expect.

Or he'd say "You're losing the emotion, let me reset you" and he'd kiss her again, even longer, his hand on her face or the back of her neck.

He said, "I need you more connected to me, more alert to me," and he'd kiss her and she'd lean into him and then pull back and he'd shoot her in that vulnerable moment right after, very close up, her eyes searching his.

I was always framed as professional, always had technical justification, just another tool in his photographer's toolkit, no different from adjusting a light or changing a backdrop.

I sat in the chair watching my girlfriend get kissed repeatedly by another man and accepted it, saw the effect on her, and came to enjoy it. She

seemed to really respond to it, to him.

She stopped looking shocked when he did it, started appearing ready for it, even aroused by it, which I'm sure made even better pictures. That first session when he'd kissed her she'd gone wide-eyed and frozen, but now she leaned into them, anticipated them even, and would tilt her face up when he came close like she knew what was coming and even wanted it. It was happening a lot.

After one particularly long kiss Dillon pulled back and said, "You're getting so much better at staying in the moment. You don't pull away anymore, you just let yourself feel it."

"Thanks," Danielle said. She smiled, too, pleased with his praise, shy even about it. But I watched her accept his compliment about how well she kissed him and I felt something dark and complicated twist in my chest.

I noticed things I didn't want to notice, like how she was getting so much more comfortable being directed by Dillon in very physical ways. How she responded to his touch immediately, her body shifting exactly the way he wanted it without hesitation. How she looked at him with this open trusting expression.

She was more herself with him than with me, it sometimes seemed, or maybe she was a different self, a more confident and uninhibited version that only existed in that studio under his attention.

One session Dillon had Danielle wear a dress, something floaty and romantic. He said he wanted to do "romantic tension" shots, something with even more intimacy and connection.

He set up the camera on a timer and then turned to me and said, "I need to be in these ones, Shane. Hope that's cool."

My mouth went dry but I nodded and said, "Sure, yeah, of course, I get it."

Dillon positioned himself and Danielle together in front of the camera, his hands on her waist, and he lifted her arms up around his neck in a pose that looked exactly like a couple about to dance or about to kiss.

The camera started clicking automatically, the timer firing off shots every few seconds. Dillon leaned in and kissed her.

It wasn't a quick technical kiss but a real kiss, slow and deep, his hands on her waist pulling her closer, her arms around his neck, pulling him closer, too, and the camera kept clicking, documenting it all.

I sat in my chair watching them kiss and I was got hard despite myself, despite the sick feeling in my stomach, despite knowing this was wrong. I couldn't look away.

They broke apart and reset and kissed again for another series of shots. And again. And again. Multiple angles, multiple compositions, all of them looking like a real couple having a real moment.

When they finished Dillon went to the computer and pulled up the shots and we all gathered around the screen to look.

They were incredible. Danielle looked beautiful and vulnerable and completely lost in the moment. Dillon looked like someone who knew exactly how to touch her, how to hold her, and they looked like they belonged together.

"These are incredible," Dillon said, scrolling through them. "Danielle, you photograph so well with a partner. The connection reads as completely authentic."

Because it is authentic, I thought, but didn't say. I could tell the effect it was having on her, all that physical closeness.

That night Danielle was insatiable, pulling me into the bedroom before we'd finished dinner, telling me she wanted to try things we'd never done before, wanted me to be rougher, wanted to be on top, wanted things she'd never asked for in our two years together.

She wanted me to pull her hair. She wanted me to slap her ass. She told me to be hard and rough with her.

I gave her what she asked for, I tried to be what she wanted. She came hard and loud and completely wild, and when it was over and she fell asleep I lay there knowing exactly why this was happening.

She'd spent two hours being kissed by Dillon, being held by him, being told she was beautiful and natural and perfect, and all that energy and arousal had nowhere to go in the studio, so it came home with her and into our bed.

The desire she felt for him that couldn't be acted on there became desire for me here. I was benefiting from it while pretending not to know where it came from.

She was thinking about him, she had to be. When she closed her eyes and moved on top of me, when she made sounds I'd never heard from her before, when she came harder than she ever had with me, she was thinking about Dillon, I knew she was.

I knew it and I let it happen and I didn't say anything because the sex was incredible, more incredible than it had ever been.

I was trading her fidelity for her passion and I knew exactly what I was doing even as I pretended I didn't.

The sessions continued, twice a week now, and evening, too. I went to as many as I could, sat in my chair, and watched Dillon kiss my girlfriend, watched his hands move around her body, watched her body respond to him in ways she'd never responded to me.

I watched and got hard and went home and benefited from what he'd started in her.

I told myself it was professional, that the kissing was technique, that the poses were for the camera, but I knew I was lying.

It was something else now. It had crossed some line from professional to personal, or maybe that line had never existed, maybe I'd just wanted to believe it was there at the start.

Danielle talked about Dillon constantly now. She mentioned him coming into the restaurant, mentioned texts they exchanged about upcoming sessions, mentioned things he'd taught her, opinions he had. It was about far more than just photo shoots.

I listened and nodded and didn't say anything how much space he was taking up in our lives, in her head, in our bed.

One night after a session where I'd watched them kiss for what felt like an hour, where I'd watched his hands slide from her waist to her hips to her lower back, where I'd watched her melt into him over and over, Danielle asked me in bed, "Are you happy?"

"What do you mean?" I asked.

"With me. With us. With how things are right now."

I knew I should have said I'm not happy watching another man kiss you. I should have said we need to stop this before it goes too far.

But I looked at her in the dim light, flushed and beautiful and looking more alive than she'd ever been. I said, "Yeah. I'm totally happy."

She smiled and kissed me and pulled me on top of her. We had the kind of sex we'd never had before the photo sessions started. I knew I'd made my choice. "I'm really happy you're happy," she murmured.

I was choosing to watch and say nothing, choosing to benefit from what Dillon was doing to my girlfriend, what he was making her feel, what he was teaching her about her own body and desire.

I fell asleep that night knowing it would get worse, knowing the kissing wouldn't be the end of it, knowing there were more lines to cross, and knowing I would watch them all get crossed and do nothing to stop it.

It's what I'd become, someone who would watch his girlfriend be slowly taken from him because the sex was better and that mattered more than stopping it.

The session started like the others had, Dillon explaining his concept while I sat in my chair off to the side and Danielle stood listening carefully. But this time he said he wanted to do fashion shots, different outfits, more variety. He gestured to the wardrobe racks along the wall.

"I have a lot of options," he said, walking over and starting to flip through hangers. "Different styles, different looks. We can try a bunch and see what photographs well on you."

He pulled out a few things, showed them to Danielle, casual clothes and dresses and structured pieces, and then he said almost offhandedly, "I also have some beautiful lingerie pieces. Very tasteful, elegant. Would photograph amazing on you."

Danielle's eyes went wide and she looked over at me immediately. I felt the weight of the moment settle on me.

If I objected I was the controlling boyfriend who couldn't handle his girlfriend doing professional modeling work. If I agreed I was giving permission for something I knew was crossing another line.

"If you're comfortable," I heard myself say, and the words felt hollow even as I said them.

Danielle looked uncertain but she nodded and said, "Okay, I guess we can try."

"Really appreciate you being so cool, man," Dillon called over to me. "Really glad you're here to give your girlfriend the nod." He nodded at me.

He pulled out several options from a section of the wardrobe I hadn't noticed before, expensive-looking pieces in black and white and deep colors, lace and silk and delicate straps. He laid them out on a nearby table.

"Just pick whichever one feels right for now," he said. "You can change behind the screen."

Danielle took a black lace set and went behind a folding screen in the corner. I sat in my chair feeling my heart pound. Dillon set up his lights and adjusted his camera like this was completely normal, completely routine.

When Danielle emerged out from behind the screen she was in the black sheer lace bra and matching underwear, her arms crossed over her stomach, self-conscious and uncertain.

But Dillon immediately started directing her, his tone completely professional and matter-of-fact.

"Arms down, shoulders back. You look incredible, just relax into it."

Within minutes she was posing, her self-consciousness fading under his direction and praise. I watched from my chair as he photographed my girlfriend in lingerie, watched him move around her with the camera, watched her gain confidence with each click.

He came over to adjust her constantly, his hands on her shoulders moving them down, his fingers adjusting the strap of her bra so it sat better on her skin, his hands on her hips shifting her position.

"Turn slightly. Good. Chin up. Perfect."

His hand slid down her bare back, adjusting her posture. It rested on her lower back just above the waistband of her underwear. I watched his fingers press against her skin.

He caught my eye over Danielle's shoulder and winked, grinned, and said, "She's doing amazing, man. She's a total natural."

I managed to nod, my mouth too dry to speak.

They shot for maybe twenty minutes like that and then Dillon said to try another option. Danielle went behind the screen and came out in a white silk set, even more revealing than the black lace, and the process repeated.

More posing, more direction, more of Dillon's hands all over her body adjusting straps and positioning her hips and moving her hair off her shoulders. He repositioned her bra while Danielle looked up and away as though it was a coat or her hair.

Before outfit changes he would kiss her casually, "to keep your energy up" he'd say. She'd accept it without question, would lean into it before he pulled back, would begin to go to him before she scurried behind the screen with another set, smiling and excited. One time he was setting something with his camera and didn't notice her come up to him where she tilted his face up and closed her hands around his cheeks and took him the way he'd been taking her. Then she skipped away laughing and gave me a tiny wave of her fluttering fingers.

They went through different lingerie sets, each one more revealing, each one making Danielle look more confident and beautiful, like someone who

belonged in a magazine or on a billboard.

I sat in my chair watching it all, hard despite myself, sick and aroused and unable to look away. I knew I should have told him that's enough, but I couldn't.

When the session ended Danielle went behind the screen to change back into her regular clothes. Dillon showed me some of the shots on his computer.

She looked incredible. Professional and elegant and sensual, the lighting making her skin glow, the poses making her body look perfect.

"These are very good," Dillon said quietly, scrolling through them. "She's really come into her own as a subject."

Danielle came out from behind the screen dressed in her clothes again. She was glowing, flushed and energized. We said goodbye to Dillon and left.

In the car she was quiet, not talking the way she usually did after sessions. I drove in silence not knowing what to say.

"Was that okay do you think?" she asked, her voice small. "The lingerie thing?"

"You looked beautiful," I said, because it was true and because I didn't know what else to say.

"I wasn't sure if you'd be okay with it."

"It was professional," I said, repeating the lie I'd been telling myself for weeks now.

That night she told me what she wanted before we even made it to the bedroom, told me she needed me to be rougher, to take control, to give her something different.

I tried to be what she wanted, tried to match the intensity she was asking for. She came hard, loud and uninhibited and completely lost. She got on her elbows and knees and waved her ass up at me where I knelt behind her, and begged me to fuck her. She was an entirely different person from before. None of this was in her before the photo shoots.

I lay there tortured in the dark thinking about Dillon's hand all over her lower back, about his fingers adjusting her bra straps, adjusting her tits, about the way she'd looked in those photos, confident and sensual and nothing like the shy reserved girl I'd started dating.

He was changing her so much. The Danielle who existed in that studio was becoming more real than the Danielle who existed here with me.

After another couple of sessions, each one pushing further than the last, Dillon made an offer I wasn't expecting.

"Shane, you've been watching so many sessions now. Want to actually shoot one? I can show you how."

I looked up from my chair, surprised, uncertain what to say.

Dillon was casual about it, cleaning a lens while he talked. "It's easy, I'll set everything up, you just click. Could be fun, give you a different perspective on the process. You can get out of the chair and move around us."

Danielle's face lit up immediately. "That would be so cool, babe! You could see what it's like from behind the camera!

She was barely dressed.

I felt trapped between wanting to say no and not having a good reason to, between curiosity about what it would actually be like, and suspicion about why Dillon was offering the chance to me.

"Sure," I heard myself say. "Yeah, okay."

"Next time," he said.

The next session Dillon spent the first fifteen minutes showing me the cameras, explaining the settings, how to focus, where to click, how to move with it.

"It's pretty intuitive once you get the hang of it," he said, positioning me. "Just keep shooting. Don't stop. Capture everything. The best shots usually happen in the moments between poses. Don't stop shooting no matter what you see, no matter how it feels. You'll see, it's about the emotion of the viewer too, every bit as much as it's the emotion of the subjects."

I remembered how he got Danielle to start showing her emotions.

He and Danielle moved to the set hand in hand, and I looked at them through the viewfinder, saw Danielle's face framed and focused in a way I'd never seen it before, saw her the way Dillon had been seeing her for months now.

"Okay Danielle, let's start simple," Dillon said. He began directing her through poses.

But now I was the one clicking, the one capturing each moment. It felt different being behind the camera, felt like I was complicit in a new way, like I was participating instead of just observing.

Dillon moved around Danielle adjusting her constantly, his hands on her shoulders, her waist, her hips. I clicked, documenting each touch, each

adjustment.

He came back to me, started moving me around, his hands on my hips making me duck down, making me twist and come forward, making me come in close, telling me to feel it the same way he had told Danielle to feel it.

Danielle was twisting and ducking and posing. I was moving around her with the camera, Dillon guiding me, and then letting me go, letting me do it, and praising me the same way he'd praised her, told me I was a natural too.

"Keep going, stay in it, be the eye," he murmured close to me. "No matter what you feel, just let yourself feel it, let it flow through you." He was saying everything to me as the one behind the camera that he'd said to Danielle in front of the camera.

He moved into the frame and I paused. "No no," he said. "Keep shooting. Keep going. No thinking."

Then he leaned in and kissed Danielle in front of me. He pulled back and looked at me and said, "Keep shooting, Shane. No matter what. Let yourself feel it all."

I clicked away.

They kissed again, longer this time, his hand on her face, her hand coming up to his. I kept clicking, kept capturing it, frame after frame of my girlfriend kissing another man while I documented it from behind the lens, moving around them.

Dillon's hands moved to her waist, then lower to her hips, then around to her lower back. I clicked through all of it, watching through the viewfinder as he touched her, and as she responded to his touch.

"I'm going to try something more intimate," Dillon said, not looking at me. I didn't know if he was asking permission or just narrating what was about to happen.

His hands slid up under Danielle's top, his fingers now on her bare skin. I clicked, capturing the moment his hands disappeared under fabric, captured Danielle's face as she felt his touch on her stomach, her ribs.

The session stopped being a session and became something else, became touching and making out, Dillon's hands all over Danielle's body while I photographed it all.

His hands moved higher under her shirt, over her back, sliding down to the waistband of her jeans. Her arms raised and fell around his neck. Their

bodies pressed together. All of it was framed in my viewfinder, all of it captured click by click by click.

I should have put down the camera and told him that's enough.

But I kept shooting, kept clicking, kept documenting everything that was happening in front of me.

Dillon suddenly pulled back and said, "That's good for today."

Danielle was flushed and breathing hard, her shirt disheveled, her hair messed up. I lowered the camera and we all stood in the sudden silence of the studio.

Dillon came over and took the camera from me and started going through the shots, scrolling through hundreds of images, and then he said, "Let me download these to your phone so you can see your work. You're very good, a very quick learner."

He connected my phone and transferred the files, hundreds of photos filling my camera roll, and when he handed my phone back to me he said, "You've got a good eye, man. These are solid."

We left and in the car Danielle was quiet, and when we got home, she went straight to the bedroom dragging me, and before I could say anything, she was pulling me toward the bed, desperate and urgent.

She was frantic about it, vocal and demanding. Later, after she was asleep, I picked up my phone and started looking through the photos I'd taken.

There were hundreds of shots of Danielle and Dillon together, his hands all over her body, their mouths entwined, his hands under her shirt, her face in moments of vulnerability and arousal.

I'd documented it all, had captured every touch, every kiss, every intimate moment.

I was the documentarian of my own humiliation, the official photographer of my girlfriend being slowly taken by another man.

I scrolled through the images and I got hard despite the sick feeling in my stomach, despite knowing exactly what I'd become.

I'd gone from observer to enabler, from watching to actively creating the record of what was happening. I'd done it willingly, too, had agreed to it, had clicked the shutter over and over while Dillon touched my girlfriend in ways I was supposed to be the only one touching her.

The photos were good, professional quality, intimate and emotional and real.

And they were all on my phone now, hundreds of them, a permanent record of what I'd allowed to happen, what I'd helped create.

I put the phone down and lay there in the dark next to Danielle and I thought about what I'd done, about how I'd crossed from being the boyfriend who watched to being the boyfriend who documented, who facilitated, who participated.

Nothing had stopped me from putting down the camera. Nothing had forced me to keep shooting when Dillon's hands went up under her shirt.

I'd chosen to keep clicking, chose to capture it all, chose to be part of it instead of stopping it.

The sessions had become routine by then, twice a week like clockwork. I sometimes sat in my chair watching, sometimes moved behind the camera shooting while Dillon directed Danielle through poses that got more intimate each time.

Danielle mentioned Dillon coming to the restaurant more often, not just once or twice a week but three or four times, and not always with clients.

"Dillon came in for lunch today," she'd say casually over dinner. "Sat at the bar by himself."

"What did you guys talk about?" I'd ask, trying to sound curious rather than suspicious.

"Just stuff he wants to try with me."

I'd nod and not push it, but I noticed she was mentioning him more and more, noticed he was taking up more space in her conversations, in her thoughts. She began to text me that I didn't need to come get her, that Dillon was okay to drive her home.

"He's there now?"

"He texted me."

One night she brought this up almost offhandedly while we were getting ready for bed. "Dillon suggested we do an overnight shoot," she said, taking off her earrings carefully in the mirror. "He knows this location about two hours north, industrial place, something abandoned. It would be totally different from the studio work he said. Increase my range he said."

My stomach dropped, immediate and sharp.

"Overnight?" I said.

"Yeah, he said we'd leave Saturday morning, shoot all day, stay overnight, shoot again Sunday morning in different light, and come back

Sunday. He said the light there is incredible and we'd want to catch it both days."

I stood trying to process this, trying to find words for the objection I felt rising in my throat.

"He said you could come too if you want," Danielle added quickly. "He said three people could fit in his car fine."

"Do you want me to come?" I asked. I heard how careful my voice was, how measured.

She hesitated for just a second, but it was enough.

"I mean, you can if you want to," she said, not quite meeting my eyes.

I realized she didn't want me there, she wanted to do this alone with Dillon, wanted whatever was going to happen without me watching, without me documenting.

"I have work stuff that weekend anyway," I lied. "Project deadline. But you should go if you want to."

"Are you sure?" she asked. She sounded relieved.

"Yeah, it sounds like a good opportunity. Two hotel rooms, obviously," she laughed.

"Obviously."

Though my stomach clenched about it, they left that Saturday morning, Dillon picking Danielle up at eight. I stood at the window watching her get into his car with an overnight bag, watching them drive away together.

I spent the weekend alone in our apartment imagining what was happening, imagining the perfect lighting and natural setting and hotel rooms and all the things I wasn't there to see.

I tried to distract myself with TV and video games and work I'd brought home, but I kept checking my phone, kept waiting for texts that didn't come, kept thinking about Danielle and Dillon two hours north doing whatever they were doing.

Sunday evening she came home around seven. When she walked through the door she was glowing and exhausted at the same time. She wouldn't quite make eye contact with me.

"So how was it?" I asked.

"It was amazing," she said, dropping her bag by the door. "The location was incredible, the light was perfect, we got so many good shots."

"Can I see some?"

She pulled out her phone and showed me, swiping through hundreds of photos. She was right, they were beautiful. Outdoor shots in natural light, her in flowy dresses I didn't recognize, standing on beaches and in fields and against rock formations, the light making her look ethereal and perfect. The stuff shot inside the abandoned plant were spectacular.

There was nothing explicitly wrong with any of them, nothing I could point to and say that's inappropriate.

But they felt intimate in a way I couldn't articulate, felt like they came from a place I wasn't part of, like they documented something private between her and Dillon.

"These are so beautiful," I said, because they were.

"He's really talented," she said quietly.

We went to bed, but this time she said she was way too exhausted for "that" she laughed, and she rolled over and fell asleep instantly.

The overnight trip had been some turning point. Whatever had been building over months of sessions had crystallized during those two days I wasn't there to watch, during that time they'd spent alone together.

Something had happened, I knew it even without knowing what it was, knew it in the way she wouldn't meet my eyes, in the way she'd been so tired in bed suddenly, in the way those photos felt intimate despite being technically innocent.

I'd never know exactly what happened, I would never see the photos that didn't make it to her phone, would never hear the conversations they had in the car or over dinner or in whatever hotel they'd stayed in.

That's what I'd given up by not going, by lying about work stuff, by giving her permission to go alone with him.

I'd traded certainty for deniability, had chosen not to see rather than confront what I might have seen.

And she'd wanted it that way, too. She didn't hesitate when I asked if she wanted me there, she was even relieved when I said I couldn't come.

She wanted time alone with Dillon, time without me watching or documenting or being alert to everything and I'd given it to her.

I lay there next to her listening to her breathe and I thought about all the choices I'd made that had led here, every time I'd said yes instead of no, every time I'd encouraged instead of objected, every time I'd watched or photographed instead of stopping it.

I'd built this situation piece by piece, had constructed the framework that allowed this overnight thing to happen, and now I was lying in the consequences of those choices knowing I had no one to blame but myself.

Dillon texted Danielle on a Tuesday night around seven. I watched her read the message and saw her face change, saw something shift in her expression.

"He wants to do a session tonight," she said. "Says he has an idea he wants to try while it's fresh. You're invited too, of course."

"Tonight?" I said. "It's already seven."

"He said around nine. Says it won't take long but he really wants to capture this concept."

So we went to the studio at nine, the industrial area darker and quieter than it was during the day, and when we got upstairs, Dillon had the space set up differently than usual.

The lighting was dimmer, more intimate, just a few soft lights creating pools of warm glow against the darkness, and there was music playing quietly, something ambient and atmospheric.

"Thanks for coming on short notice," Dillon said, greeting us at the door. "I've been thinking about this concept all day, wanted to shoot it while it was clear in my head."

"What's the concept?" Danielle asked, already taking things off.

"Fine art. Really pushing boundaries, really exploring vulnerability and intimacy. If you're up for it."

Danielle looked at me and I nodded, not trusting my voice. She said, "Sure!"

Dillon gestured to the wardrobe area. "There's a silk robe there, start with that. And only that."

I sat in my chair and Danielle went to change. When she came back she was wearing the short silk robe, black. I could tell from the way it moved that she wasn't wearing anything underneath it, as per Dillon's request.

The session began and Dillon directed her through poses. The robe kept opening, kept revealing more skin, before he said, "Let it fall" and Danielle let the robe slide off her shoulders and suddenly she was naked. I could tell instantly it was not the first time. She didn't hesitate. She even glanced at me as though catching herself, as though realizing she just gave that fact away.

Now fully naked, Dillon was touching her more than usual, his hands over her skin constantly. He was kissing her more too, deep slow kisses that she leaned into fully. I sat up in my chair watching and feeling something dark and inevitable building.

"Shane," Dillon said, not looking away from Danielle. "Come on and shoot this for us."

I got up and moved to the camera on its tripod and looked through the viewfinder. Through the lens I watched Dillon pull Danielle close and kiss her deeply, his hands over her bare back. I clicked the shutter.

They kissed for a long time and I kept shooting, kept clicking, kept documenting, and then I watched Dillon's hand slide down her body, watched it move between her legs. I heard Danielle make a sound, a small moan. I saw her kick her leg.

"Just keep shooting," Dillon said, his voice quiet. I kept clicking.

Through the lens I watched his hand move on her, watched Danielle's face change, watched her mouth fall open and her eyes flutter closed and her whole body respond to what he was doing to her.

She became louder, making sounds I'd never heard from her, uninhibited and desperate, nothing like the quiet controlled way she usually was in foreplay. I clicked through all of it, documenting every moment, every expression, every sound.

Dillon kept working on her between her legs despite how I could see, how we all could hear, how she was building to something. "Keep on it," he murmured to me even as Danielle hung not him unable to stand on her own. I could hear the wetness he was bringing out of her. I could see through the viewfinder how her body trembled and her knees buckled.

"Don't stop," he said to me.

I moved around them as he sank his fingers inside her. She gasped and breathed hard and emitted high pitched cries. She clutched at his hair and clenched her eyes. Her toes curled and she bit her lip.

I clicked away because Dillon told me to.

He brought her near to orgasm and I watched it happen through the viewfinder. I watched her come apart under his hand while I stood behind the camera capturing it all, and when she came down, he didn't stop, he just started building her back up again.

He edged her like that, bringing her close and then stopping, making her whimper and beg, making her say please and don't stop and I need it. I

stood photographing my girlfriend begging another man to let her come while my hands shook with the camera.

He controlled her completely. She was whimpering from the intensity of it, her eyes glassy while she moaned and shook.

He laid her down on the couch. She writhed and contorted on his fingers, me all the while hovering over her and around her clicking like a mad-man.

Finally he pushed her over. She clutched him with both hands around his wrist, arched so high in her back before she pushed her feet down and lifted herself between the top of her head and her heels and went stiff as a coil of steel.

She shook like something electrical before collapsing down and curling away from both of us.

Dillon said came up, cleaned his fingers in his mouth, and said, "That's enough for tonight."

I helped Danielle put the robe back on, as gentle and tender as I could be. She was still trembling and barely able to stand. I was hard and sick and paralyzed.

Dillon took the camera and downloaded the photos to my phone like he always did, hundreds of shots filling my camera roll, and we left.

In the car Danielle wouldn't speak, wouldn't look at me, just sat staring out the window with her arms wrapped around herself.

When we got home she went straight to bed. Before I could say anything, she pulled me to the bed, desperate and urgent. She took me in her mouth and moaned deeply.

When I entered her, she came immediately, within seconds, like she was still on edge from what Dillon had done to her. She was asleep just as fast, too.

I eventually picked up my phone and started looking through the photos I'd taken.

There were hundreds of shots of Dillon touching Danielle, of his hand between her legs all wet, of her face in ecstasy, of her begging, of her coming while I documented it all.

I photographed another man making my girlfriend come, I stood clicking the shutter while he rubbed her and controlled her and owned her body to a degree I never had.

I was the documentarian of my own complete humiliation, the official photographer of my girlfriend being taken by another man. I'd done it willingly, had agreed to it, had captured every moment in perfect detail.

The photos were explicit and intimate and beautiful in their way, showing Danielle more vulnerable and open than I'd ever seen her, showed her experiencing pleasure I'd never given her.

And they were all on my phone now, a permanent record of what I'd allowed to happen, what I'd facilitated, what I'd helped create.

I put the phone down and lay there next to Danielle listening to her breathe. I knew that next time could be worse.

Dillon's text came on a Thursday afternoon: "Big shoot plans tonight. Both of you must come."

We went to the studio at eight and when we walked in I saw immediately that he'd set up something special.

There was a bedroom set in the middle of the space, a real bed with dark sheets and pillows, intimate lighting creating a warm glow around it, everything carefully arranged and deliberate.

"Tonight is about complete vulnerability," Dillon said, looking at both of us. "Complete truth. No more pretending this is just about technique or artistry. This is about capturing something real."

I knew what was going to happen, I thought. Danielle knew. We all knew.

Nobody said it out loud.

Dillon gave Danielle a choice of lingerie to wear. "Or nothing," he said privately to her.

I saw her smirk and her shoulder shoot up, her eyebrows raise. Not taking her eyes off him while he stood close to her, she stripped for him, opening her shirt, dropping it into his waiting hand, undoing her skirt and handing him that too. Then she turned and pulled her hair up for him to unclasp her bra. She didn't pause one moment to bend at her knees and waist and hook her thumbs in the waist of her panties and draw them off her legs, too.

He turned and handed my girlfriend's clothes to me and gestured with his chin for me to lay them over the couch. "Lady chose nothing," he said to me.

He directed naked Danielle onto the bed and she nearly skipped to it. He started with conventional poses, her sitting, then lying down, then adjusting

positions, but it became clear within minutes that this wasn't really about posing anymore.

He climbed onto the bed with her and they started kissing, and then touching, and then his clothes were coming off piece by piece too. I stood watching from my chair knowing exactly where this was going, my heart pounding but my legs paralyzed.

Dillon looked at me. "Get behind the camera. Shoot everything. Never stop. Don't come in front of the camera. You're the photog."

I got the camera and lifted it to look through the viewfinder, and through the lens I watched Dillon position himself between Danielle's legs, watched him look directly at the camera, at me.

"Just keep shooting," he said.

I clicked the shutter.

He lifted one of her legs and then the other, and as he sank down my girlfriend's feet slid down his bare back. He came low enough to kiss her breasts, and she gasped and smiled, watched down her body. He kissed down her belly and she laughed and squirmed. He kissed her hips and she dropped her mouth open, popped her eyes wide.

I clicked away moving around in every position above and around her. She was good with cameras now, ignoring me.

He lifted her hips with his hands around her ass and kissed her between her legs and she instantly shot back with her head, twisted her fists in the sheets, and groaned out loud at the head board behind her.

Click click click I went.

I didn't stop, though my naked girlfriend twisted and clenched and slapped the bed. She pushed her hips up into his face and twisted her fists in his hair driving his face down. "Baby!" she cried out loud, and her body shook so violently I stopped shooting a moment.

When she subsided, Dillon came up from her pussy with his face wet, and he looked over his shoulder at me.

"You stopped," he said.

I began shooting again, and he snickered and yanked Danielle's body down under him by her ankles.

The rough treatment made her squeal. Through the lens I watched Dillon pull up her knees, push them apart, and heft his thick long cock in his hand. He touched it to her and she jolted from it. He teased her with the

tip and she laughed and moaned and chased him with her folds leaking over his tip.

“Don’t!” she pouted at him with a grin and she reached for him, but he pulled back with his hips and tsk’d-tsk’d her. She punched the bed under her with mounting frustration. Her hair fell over her face wildly.

I continued to click away. Even while, through the viewfinder, I watched Dillon push his stiff, straining cock into Danielle, watched it happen slowly, watched her mouth fall open and her back arch up and her hands grip the white sheets.

I kept clicking, kept shooting, kept documenting.

She made sounds I'd never heard from her, loud broken sounds of pleasure. Dillon started moving and I clicked through all of it, captured every moment, every expression on her face, every movement of their bodies coming together. I saw her wet flesh fold around the length of his rod, grip it, suck him deeper into her.

He began to fuck her in missionary first and I shot it all, saw her face contort through the lens, saw her react to being filled by someone else, someone who knew exactly what he was doing with her, someone who was giving her something I'd never been able to give her, not quite like that.

Then he pulled out of her and flipped her over without care and positioned her on her hands and knees, pulling her hips up, pushing her around like he always did for the camera, but harsher now, rougher. He looked at me and said, "Change your angle, get this from the side."

I moved around and adjusted the focus and kept shooting, documenting Dillon fucking my girlfriend from this new angle, watched through the viewfinder as Dillon fucked her from behind, his hands on her hips pulling her back onto him.

Danielle was screaming now, loud and uninhibited and completely lost in it, nothing like the quiet controlled girl who needed the lights off, nothing like the shy reserved person I'd started dating, nothing like what she used to be.

Then Dillon rolled over and she knew the cue, climbed on top of him, straddled him facing the camera, facing me behind it. She sank down onto his cock and started riding him while looking directly at the lens, at me.

With out eye contact through the viewfinder, Danielle looking at me while she sank herself down on another man, while she moaned and moved and took him deep inside her over and over.

I kept clicking, kept shooting, my girlfriend being completely transformed into someone I barely recognized, someone loud and demanding and sexual in ways I'd never seen.

Dillon was in total control, his hands on her hips guiding her movements, his voice telling her what to do. She obeyed immediately, responded to every direction, gave him everything he asked for.

He tapped her body and she instantly knew to suck him and lower her pussy on his mouth at the same time. He tapped her again and she sat in his lap facing him, bouncing on him.

It went on for what felt like hours, Dillon fucking my girlfriend in different positions, making her come multiple times, her voice breaking with screams and sobs. I captured all of it, hundreds of shots, thousands maybe, my finger on the shutter button clicking automatically.

Dillon's rhythm changed and his breathing got harsh and he said "I'm going to come," and Danielle said "yes, inside me, baby," and I watched through the lens as he pushed deeper inside her one last time and held himself there, watched him pulse and finish inside her, watched her face as she felt it fill her.

I clicked through all of it, not stopping like he ordered me.

They lay tangled together in the bed, the bed a mess, both breathing hard, Dillon's arm around Danielle and her head on his chest. I stood behind the camera still, frozen, not knowing what to do.

"Come here, man," Dillon said. I lowered the camera and walked over on unsteady legs.

He reached for the camera and pulled up the screen and started scrolling through the shots I'd taken even while he and Danielle still reclined in the bed. She looked up at the back of the camera with her head on his chest. She'd pulled the sheet over them both.

"You got some incredible shots tonight," he said. "This is real art. This is the truth of what she is, what she's become."

Danielle nodded and twisted around to kiss him briefly. "What you made me," she said privately. Looking over at me, she said, "You did real well, Shane, you really did."

I looked at the screen too and saw what I'd documented, saw Danielle's face in ecstasy, saw Dillon inside her, saw the moment he came, saw all of it in perfect detail.

"I'll send these to your phone," Dillon said. "Can you get her clothes?"

I went to the couch. They kissed and hugged in bed, until he whispered something to her and she laughed and he slapped her ass as she got up and out of the bed, wincing with some pain. "I can hardly walk!" she said and she laughed and slapped at his leg. "You got to stop doing that to me!"

She glanced at me and looked quickly away.

I handed her her clothes one by one in the reverse order Dillon took them off her. Dressed but before we left, she went back to him where he hunched over his laptop at his big glass desk, still in his open robe, and she threw her arms around his neck, gave him a big kiss, and slipped her hand inside his robe to squeeze him and laugh devilishly.

"Thursday then, baby?" she said, and she gave him a wave over her shoulder and blew him a kiss as she rushed to catch up with me at the door.

We left the studio, Danielle falling quiet beside me in the car.

At home, she said with a chuckle, "Maybe not tonight, babes, but don't worry, just give me a couple days."

I looked at her.

She squeezed her hand in her lap and bent over. "So sore!" she groaned, and she chuckled some more.

I lay with my phone on the nightstand I knew was full of the photos I'd taken, photos that proved what I was and what she was, and what I'd become.

I'd documented my own complete loss. I stood behind that camera and clicked the shutter while another man fucked my girlfriend, while she came for him over and over, while she looked at me and lowered herself on him and gave him everything.

I'd chosen this with every click, with every session, with every moment I'd said yes instead of no, with every time I'd encouraged her to do the shoots, with every time I'd sat in that chair or stood behind that camera instead of walking away.

But the version of Danielle that existed now, confident and sexual and uninhibited, was the version I'd always wanted her to be. Dillon had created that version while I watched and documented.

Even now, lying there knowing what I'd lost, knowing what I'd allowed to happen, knowing what I'd participated in creating, I couldn't honestly say I regretted it.

Because I got to see her become that person. I got to witness her transformation. I got to be part of it in my own way, even if that way was

just clicking a shutter while someone else took her completely apart.

I knew I'd look at those photos again, too, knew I'd click through them all and see it all over again, see what I'd captured, see what I'd allowed, see what I'd done.

I knew that if I could go back to the beginning, to that first night when she mentioned the photographer at her restaurant, I'd make all the same choices again.

Because this version of her was worth it to me. This transformed, confident, sexual version of Danielle was worth everything I'd given up to help create her.

That's what I told myself lying there in the dark, and I almost believed it. Who was I kidding though? She was no more mine than the pictures of her were.

In the morning, Danielle took her time getting up out of bed. I went to wake her with coffee but found she was long awake, she'd been texting on her phone. When she saw me come in, she cooed to me and sat up against the headboard and patted the bed beside her.

"We haven't changed, have we?" she said.

I twisted inside with my internal conflict, excited about what she'd become sexually, but appalled at what I'd allowed to bring that about.

"Well..." I started, but she threw her arms around my neck and sank her tongue into my mouth.

"I know I've changed, you can say it, babes."

I laughed at the understatement. "Yeah, maybe just a little."

She pulled my hand over her lap under the sheets, separated out my middle finger, ran the tip over her pussy. She was boiling hot. I circled her and entered her.

She moved her hips and gasped against my mouth. "You love it, say it," she said, and she lashed my mouth with her tongue. "I saw how hard you were taking pictures of me."

I laughed again and she pushed herself up and over me, straddled me, wrapped her cool hand around my cock, and sank down on me. She was so hot inside, I worried it was too scalding.

She moved her hips in ways like someone taught her how to dance. She hung her hands around the back of my neck and kissed my face. The way she fucked me, the fact that she was fucking me, rather than always me doing most of the work, was a complete change in her.

“Do you love it or not?” she said. She leaned down and drew her tongue around my lips. “Dani needs to know,” she groaned.

His name for her, I noted.

“I love it,” I said.

She breathed out and grunted and sped up her movements. I felt her clench inside and I startled.

“You love that, too, don’t you,” she said and she laughed.

It felt like a thousand tiny fingers grasping at me inside her. “Dillon taught me that too,” she whispered in my ear.

I nearly lost my breath. But she stopped moving on me and used only her internal muscles. She brought her glassy eyes to mine, watched my face and mouth as she stroked me inside her pussy tight and mind-blowing, until I couldn’t take it anymore and I exploded up into her.

She flew off me and ducked down and sucked on me and lashed me with her tongue and drained me of everything.

After, we reclined in bed with coffees leaning up against the headboard. “So Dillon says he wants to take me with him to LA for the weekend. He’s got some business or a show or something.” She wrapped her hand around my still half stiff cock. “Is that okay?”

“For a weekend, just you and Dillon?”

“That’s okay, isn’t it?”

I stared at the opposite wall a moment. “Two rooms again, I hope.”

She laughed uproariously like I’d just made the funniest joke and popped up out of bed and padded naked across the room. “He said he wants to show me off,” she said and she held the doorway to the bathroom and kicked a leg up behind her. “His new girl,” she said full of pride and she laughed with delight and went inside. I heard the shower come on.

He picked her up Saturday. He waved at me from his car, and I waved back. She threw herself over his lap and kissed him deeply and long even as he tried to start rolling away. She was in a tight, short black dress he bought her, and underwear he bought her too.

In fact her bag was filled with things he bought her. She showed me while she packed, light things, expensive things, lots of straps and lace and satin. “Isn’t it great?”

I nodded. But then I got up my nerve. “Are you going to be with him now?”

She looked at me and blinked like I was dim. “All weekend babes,” she said.

“Shared room?”

“You already know that.”

“Am I losing you?”

She laughed out loud and shook her head and realized what I was feeling in one swooning moment, and she came over to me, drew her arms around my waist, and pulled me close to kiss my forehead.

“Babes, no,” she said, kissing me all over my face. “Of course not! Dillon can’t look after a girl, he doesn’t even want a relationship, you saw the way he lives.” She shook her head like the idea was ridiculous and she rolled her eyes.

“I’ll be back late Sunday good as new, you’ll see. We’ll go right back to normal, you and me. The team!”

But I wasn’t high fiving her. “What is this, then, Danielle?”

She looked at me with that confused expression again. “It’s just a photo shoot, babes.” She slung her bag over her shoulder dressed in that tight and too-short black dress, and she tapped at her phone. “My man is here,” she said, and she kissed me quickly and dashed out the door. “Be good!” she called back.